

PROCESSING THE WORDS

You can use your word processor to type a single page document, and at the same time create an entire book in it. Therefore, your wish list from a word processor may differ depending on the actual use you make of it.

Formatting

Except for 602Text, all the other software gave us a number of paragraph formatting features, including auto-correct and auto-format functions. 602Pro didn't have any options for hanging indents or drop-caps and neither were there any widow or orphan control options.

All the software worked differently in terms of retaining formats of copied text. 602Text converted any pasted text to the default formatting of the paragraph, and didn't even retain Web formatting. Word Pro retains the formatting of the paragraph that has been copied and will not take the format of the paragraph where it is being copied.

Word 2002, in spite of its Smart Tag option, was the most troublesome while pasting text. We chose the option Retain Source Formatting, but when we pasted text, the results did not match the source.

The Reveal Formatting option in Word allows you to identify a format based on a style and then select all the paragraphs in the document that match the style at one go. Quite useful when working with lengthy documents if you want to globally change formatting options.

Grammar and spell-check

Only Word Pro and Word 2002 had gram-

mar check functions, and in most of the software, spell-check was not enabled by default. In Word Pro, if you misspell a word, the options relating to it show up as a tiny question mark in the bottom palette. You have to click on the question mark to get the options and people can often miss this. The right-click option of Word is much better in that sense.

Tables

We thought the creation of tables would be simple in all the suites, but 602Text proved us wrong. Try creating a table and



Collaborative tools in Office XP: Quite informative

the first thing you notice is that by default, cell gridlines aren't drawn. You cannot select rows or columns, or select the table, so to have the gridlines, you have to select all the cells and add the cell gridlines first, before you can get to work. Only Office XP had the feature of drawing a table, and splitting rows and columns using the toolbar. Word Pro had an interesting feature of specifying different gutter width (the distance of the text from the cell boundary). We don't know what exactly this will be used for in a table, but you can definitely make your table look a bit different from the rest.

Lengthy documents

Section-breaks, column breaks, headers and footers are essential options if you are working on a report or any lengthy document such as a book. 602Pro and StarOffice Writer were disappointing—they don't support portrait and landscape mode within the same document for different sections. Word Pro allows you to create divisions that can behave like a totally different document with different styles, headers, footers, etc. and within divisions you can again have sections that can have different headers and footers. All the suites were similar when it came to creating the table of contents and index based on a defined style.

Collaboration

Word Pro and Word 2002 have a number of collaborative tools that make distributing work among co-authors or revisioners simpler. Both allow you to protect a document for just revisioning purposes (that is, when the revisioner opens the

document, the Track Changes option will be set by default), and you can send the document via the default e-mail client to the intended person.

While Word Pro and StarOffice allow you to mark comments along with the tracked changes, the most interesting features come from Word 2002. When you are in the tracking mode, Word 2002 jots down comments on the side about everything you do. So, if you delete text, you get a comment about text being deleted, and if you change formatting (make a word bold), the comments again appear. Quite useful in a collaborative environment, to keep track of the changes that have been made.

Working with 602Text is hardly appealing, and the lack of functions means it still has some way to go before entering the big league. With a number of interesting features, and icons that are quite intuitive and elegant to use, Lotus Word Pro can be quite useful, especially for long documents and reports. But if you want something for a multi-purpose and varied application use, ranging from publishing and collaborative work to simple documents, **Word 2002** scores. Word 2002 tries to increase the intuitive level of the software with some excellent concepts, and enhances quite a number of existing features. →

Rich with Text

We checked out the suites for their saving options and any compatibility issues they had. Specifically, we checked for compatibility with respect to opening a Word 2002 document. Except for 602Pro, the rest of the suites managed that with ease. However, all software had problems with the tables created in Word that had split cells. In case you think compatibility problems might arise, the safest bet is to save it in Rich Text Format (RTF).

Another aspect we looked at was the

Save for Web feature. When we saved the document created in StarOffice Writer with pre-defined styles to an HTML format, and opened it in Internet Explorer, we found that none of the styles were rendered properly and in some cases some of the heading styles had text missing. Even with other software recognition of styles was a problem area. Otherwise, both StarOffice Writer and 602Text have embedded support for HTML, and in these you can even insert scripts or add tags.